Sole Trader Quarterly Tracker

Guide · tax year 2026-27

This spreadsheet keeps your self-employment income, expenses and business mileage in one place, and adds them up for each Making Tax Digital quarter and for the year. It works in Microsoft Excel, Google Sheets, Apple Numbers and LibreOffice.

Please read. The tracker keeps your records and adds them up. It does not submit anything to HMRC, and it does not work out the tax you owe. To send quarterly updates, use HMRC-recognised bridging or MTD software with these figures. This is a record-keeping tool, not tax or accounting advice: check anything you are unsure about with HMRC guidance or an accountant.

What's in the download

- **Sole-Trader-Quarterly-Tracker-2026-27.xlsx**, the blank tracker you use.
- **Sole-Trader-Quarterly-Tracker-EXAMPLE.xlsx**, the same file filled in with example data, so you can see how it works.
- This guide.

Open the file

- **Excel or Numbers:** double-click the .xlsx file. If Excel shows "Protected View", click Enable Editing.
- **Google Sheets:** upload the file to Google Drive, open it, then choose File > Save as Google Sheets.
- **LibreOffice:** open the .xlsx file directly.

Set up in 3 steps

1. Go to **Settings**. Type your business name, and the year your tax year starts (type 2026 for 6 April 2026 to 5 April 2027).
2. Leave **Quarter dates** on Standard (6th to 5th) unless you have told HMRC you use calendar quarters.
3. Start recording. Type only in the cream cells.

Each tab

Tab	What it's for
Start Here	The short version of this guide.
Settings	Business name, tax year, quarter dates, mileage rates and the dropdown lists.
Income	One row per payment you receive. Choose Turnover, or Other business income for things like royalties.
Expenses	One row per payment you make, with its SA103 category. Mark it No under Allowable if it is not a deductible business cost.
Mileage	Business journeys. The simplified allowance (45p a mile for the first 10,000 car or van miles, 25p after) is worked out on the right and added to Car, van and travel expenses.
Quarterly Summary	Totals for each quarter, the year so far, and the date each update is due.
Year End	Totals in the same order as the SA103F self-employment pages, with allowable and disallowable kept apart.

Quarters and deadlines (standard dates)

Quarter	Period	Update due by
Q1	6 April to 5 July	7 August
Q2	6 July to 5 October	7 November
Q3	6 October to 5 January	7 February
Q4	6 January to 5 April	7 May

Your final declaration for the year is due by 31 January after the tax year ends. The Quarter column on every register fills itself in from the date. If it shows **Outside year** in red, that date is not in the tax year set in Settings.

Who has to use Making Tax Digital

From 6 April 2026, sole traders and landlords with qualifying income over £50,000 must keep digital records and send quarterly updates. The threshold falls to £30,000 from April 2027 and £20,000 from April 2028. Qualifying income is your total gross self-employment and property income before expenses. Check GOV.UK for the current rules.

Expense categories

Categories in the dropdown (SA103F order)
Cost of goods bought for resale or goods used
Construction industry - payments to subcontractors
Wages, salaries and other staff costs
Car, van and travel expenses
Rent, rates, power and insurance costs
Repairs and maintenance of property and equipment
Phone, fax, stationery and other office costs
Advertising and business entertainment costs
Interest on bank and other loans
Bank, credit card and other financial charges
Irrecoverable debts written off

Accountancy, legal and other professional fees
Depreciation and loss or profit on sale of assets
Other business expenses

If your turnover is under £90,000 you may be able to report expenses as a single total. Entertaining clients is never an allowable expense, and depreciation is not allowable (capital allowances are claimed instead).

Good habits

- Record things weekly. It takes minutes, and the quarterly totals are then always ready.
- Put a receipt or invoice reference on every row, and keep the receipts. HMRC can ask to see records for at least 5 years after the 31 January deadline.
- Use one copy of the file per tax year. For next year, save a copy, clear the cream cells and change the year in Settings.
- Claim either the mileage allowance or your actual vehicle costs for a vehicle, not both.

Changing the protected cells

Grey cells hold formulas and are protected without a password, so they don't get typed over by mistake. In Excel choose Review > Unprotect Sheet. Google Sheets removes this protection when you open the file.

Questions

Message the shop you bought from and include which app you use (Excel, Google Sheets, Numbers or LibreOffice).

Licence

For your own business records. You may not resell, share or redistribute the file or this guide, in original or edited form. Making Tax Digital rules and rates are as published for the 2026-27 tax year; check GOV.UK for changes.